Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.
    a. Explore where they buy food and groceries, if they have cooking appliances, and if they know how to cook food.

Excellent. We buy our food from Costco, Walmart, smiths, and rancho.

FQ: Who told you about these places? Was it IRC?

IRC didn't tell us about these spots it was the people around us. My husbands sister told us where the places were.

FQ: do you have pots and pans?

Yes

FQ: do you know how to cook?

Yes

FQ: how do you feel about cooking? Especially since you are pregnant

It is fine. A person has to adjust to their needs.

2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
    a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

At the moment the amount that we get in food stamps is not enough because my husband started working that made them less. We only get 300 dollars in food stamps.

FQ: what do you buy with food stamps?

I get the essentials like rice, oil, and other basics for the house.

FQ: do you have to add from your income?

Yes

FQ: did you face any other problems when it comes to food?

No

FQ: when you go to the grocery store, do you know what you are buying or is there a language barrier?

No

i. Explore the nature of the problem such as unemployment, low income, language barriers, and lack of knowledge about resources.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

I don't know.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

IRC, they helped us by applying to food stamps.

FQ: when your husband started working did they cut off your food stamps?

No they just made them less

FQ: did IRC give you pots and pans?

Yes but they didn't give us everything. We are 3 so they give us the bare minimum then we bought more.

i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.

ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

They encouraged us to work when we got here, which helped us.

iii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Yes.

FQ: do you have a computer at home?

Yes

FQ: do you know how to apply to food stamps?

Yes, every 3 months you have to update your paperwork at DWS but my husband takes care of this more.

FQ: do you have any difficulty doing the paperwork?

Yes sometimes we do. We ask for help from someone around us.

iv. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

I feel like they don't help a lot. Even when we came, the caseworker, it felt like he didn't care because he had more than one family so I don't know.

d. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:

SNAP

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?
Through IRC, they applied for us.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.
I felt that it was hard when they lessened the amount of food stamps. The necessities became less. So we started only getting the necessities.
FQ: now that your husband is employed and you get less from food stamps, do you worry about fulfilling your nutrition needs.?
I haven't thought of that
FQ: Did the amount of food you have at the house decrease with the decrease in EBT or did you start buying food using your income?
We started to get less food to try to avoid using our income on food.
FQ: when you had no income, full food stamps, would the food last you until the end of the month?
No
FQ: what about now?
At the beginning of the month, the first week we see a large decrease in the amount of food but we would have necessities like rice and oil. Right, there are vegetables and other things? But we buy those simply from our income.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.
N/A

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?
50%

WIC

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?
Through IRC again

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

It's a good program. I know the things I can get and the things I can not get.

(shows me the app on her phone)

We can see that I can get cheese, cereal, beans, bread, and vegetables. They give me 37 dollars for vegetables. Yogurt, milk, one carton of eggs.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

25%

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
    a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

    Of course its important for us to eat food we are used to eating. Knowing the food is healthy and food that we know how to cook.

    FQ: do you ever try to cook foods from other cultures?

    Yes sometimes

    FQ: what do you eat from your culture?

    Everything, Kbsa, mahashi, beans and meats. Shawrama.

    Sometimes I find them at Costco. Sometimes Rancho. They have arab foods.

    b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

    From Rancho.

    FQ: do you ever go to arab markets?

    Sometimes I go. I go to the afghani or shaku maku.

    c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

    They did not help, they got us food stamps and we were able to get foods we wanted on our own.

        i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

    d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

    No

    e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?

    No

        i. if yes, how did you hear about it and what has been your experience with that?

FQ: how did IRC help you?

They brought us here. They got us employed so we can buy rent. We told them that we needed help in learning English. They told us they did not bring us here to teach us, we had to work and learn from experience. We were in shock. We had no idea where we were going. They gave us a bus pass and taught us how to use maps but it was very hard.

FQ: did those hardships affect buying and preparing foods?

Yes, it affected the mental status. I started having problems with my husbands.

FQ: When you used to take the bus to get the things you needed, was it hard?

Yes, I used to get really tired. It was really hard. I have appointments as a pregnant lady, IRC at the beginning of the year they used to take us. Now they don't, so my husband has to take days off of work to take me to appointments. They even used to give us cleaning supplies, no they don't. I try to get in contact with my case worker at IRC, and she does not answer. I have to go to them if I need anything but I can't go and get help due to lack of transportation. Even if we complain, they told us that they have many families and that they need to help a lot of people. They always change our caseworker. When I told them I can not go take the bus because of foot pain, they told me to go take the bus. Even registering my daughter in school, my husband had to go do it himself.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?
   I don't think there is anything. There are a lot of people complaining that their EBT amount was taken by a hacker but it has not happened to me.
2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?
   Through the resettlement agency to help them apply. If they don't, they can try through the application.
   FQ: do you think some people have a hard time getting in communication with IRC?

Some people don't have a car so they may find it difficult to go.

FQ: is there anything you wish you had gotten help with?

Yes, those who don't have a car maybe they can help them. We used to struggle a lot so the topic frustrates me.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?
   Helping them with budgeting. To be able to make the necessities last the month.
4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?
   No